

Town of Westhampton  
Town Hall  
1 South Road  
Westhampton, MA 01027

Finance Committee Meeting Minutes  
Tuesday, March 25, 2014

The meeting convened at 6:45 PM

Present:

Finance Committee Members: Ellice Gonzalez, Jackie Brodeur, Mary Cleary, Maryanne Duggan, Aniko Giordano, Margaret Parsons, Celeste Whiting.

Additional Attendees: Cheryl Provost, Administrative Assistant; Lyn Keating, Librarian; Maureen Dempsey, Library Board of Trustees; David White, Police Department; Chris Norris, Fire Department.

1. There was no correspondence this week.
2. Reminder: There is a Town Caucus on April 14th.
3. Meet with Lyn Keating and Maureen Dempsey of the Library.

We reviewed the library's FY15 budget spreadsheet and the prepared notes from Lyn with additional information regarding the library's budget and services (see attached). Lyn noted that the library offsets costs for the town with volunteer hours, solar credits earned, recurring grants and funds from the Friends of WPL. Lyn noted that the library will earn \$5000/year for 10 years in solar credits. Margie indicated that, at the time of the solar proposal, the projections were \$10-15,000/year. Lyn also noted that the funds earned go directly into the town's general funds. She also noted that she is currently in communications with HCOG regarding their mistake of credits/payments as they currently owe the town some money. She will continue to work on that.

Lyn noted:

- The town receives \$2000 in state aid for staying certified.
- The Homestead Foundation grant is used to fund a 5hrs/week, 1099-position (does not go through town payroll) that is used for maintaining the Facebook page, the website and doing library publicity.
- The library maintains about a dozen computers with no tech help from the town. Lyn built 5 of the computers from parts.
- Steve Holt is paid to mow 1/3 of the library lawn. The rest is mowed by volunteers.
- The Friends recently purchased reusable cups and plates for preschool story time so there is no waste and less cost to the library.
- Library usage statistics as per FY2013 report (see attached).
- Last year the town granted less money than requested and the library used Fill the Shelves donations to help buy books.

The Finance Committee had questions on the budget as follows:

- There was an incorrect calculation regarding the 20% of town appropriation. It was listed as \$18,722, but should read \$17,881.

- The salary for staff librarian reflects a pay increase in excess of 2.5% (Ellice will email Lyn about this as this was noted after the library presentation was over).

4. At 7:20 we met with David White of the Police Department.

We reviewed the Police Department's budget (see attached)

David White noted the following:

- This budget includes several fixed costs.
- The WMLEC is the required regional radio communications.
- They are seeking to replace one computer from 2006.
- This year they have only spent \$290 of \$3500 to date for officer/equipment, but he anticipates needing to purchase a printer.
- The cruisers are in good shape. Prior to the end of each fiscal year, David has the cruisers thoroughly inspected to anticipate any repair needs. Currently, the sedan has 45,000 miles on it and the Expedition has 16,000 miles. The cars are budgeted on an 8-year cycle.
- This is a level-funded budget.

5. At 7:30 we met with Chris Norris of the Fire Department.

We reviewed the Fire Department's budget (see attached).

Chris noted the following:

- This is an all volunteer fire department.
- Last year they responded to approximately 175 calls (both fire and EMS)
- The department has 2 fire engines, 1 tanker, 1 rescue truck, 1 brush truck, 1 air trailer. The equipment includes 2 sets of PPE for each person and SCBA gear.
- Administrative expenses include membership fees and professional development.
- Training expenses include fees for the Hampshire County Fire Defense Association (about \$600) and Mass. Fire Academy workshops.
- Communications include \$2,177 for annual fire reports for each response, \$1,700 for e-dispatch (allowing for volunteer notification through cell phones which results in greater turnout for emergency calls), \$1,500 for reverse 911 (mass notification), and \$250 for the host/domain of the website (Chris does all other updates and maintenance on the website).
- The reverse 911 is up \$1,500 from last year because it was originally covered by a grant and now the town must take it on. Chris noted that he researched providers and is switching from Blackboard Connect to Code Red. Code Red has better reviews, more services (including notifications to cell phones) and is less expensive. Mass notification is a better way to get an emergency message to the entire town (rather than going door-

to-door). Code Red will take over on July 1. You can go to the fire department website to add your contact info to reverse 911.

- Vehicle repair/maintenance includes \$1,000/year for air quality testing, \$600/year for mass mobile, \$500/year for pump testing each engine as per NFPA.

- Equipment repair/maintenance includes testing all fire hoses at \$3,200/year (14,000 feet of hose to be pressure tested), ladder testing at \$400/year, SCBA flow tests at \$1,000/year, extrication equipment pressure test at \$1,000/year.

Ellice asked about capital requests for this year. Chris noted that he is seeking an article in the town warrant to ask for \$45,000 for 6 SCBAs if the grant he is currently applying for is not accepted. The grant would include funds for 15 brand new SCBAs and 35 face pieces totaling \$122,000 of which the town would be required to provide a 5% match. He will know about the grant in June. Chris noted that the SCBAs are needed as the current SCBAs have been revoked by NIOSH and they can't be serviced or have parts replaced.

The ambulance is ready and will go into operation on July 1. It is in the EMS budget.

6. At 7:55 we attended to other business.

We noted that the EMS budget has not been submitted yet.

We reviewed the minutes from 3/18/14. Aniko made a motion to amend the minutes to note that Cindy Landers promised to provide a revised powerpoint packet (particularly pages 2, 5 and 7) and a revised spreadsheet with information on the preschool revolving account. VOTE 7-0-0 to accept amendment.

We noted we did receive the updated powerpoint on 3/19/14. We have not received the updated spreadsheet. Ellice will email Deane Bates for the updated spreadsheet and seek clarification on the regular teacher salary increase of \$74,863 (13.8% increase).

We discussed the dates of the upcoming select board meetings and noted that if we decided on the need for an article for a debt exclusion we need to do so by April 8.

Ellice noted that the Finance Committee can only vote on the total amount that goes to any particular department and not on how they spend it within the department. We should keep that in mind when we are approving/rejecting budgets. She also noted that we may need to vote on what information we have since we may not receive all the information that we are seeking.

VOTE 7-0-0 to accept minutes as amended.

7. Margie asked for volunteers to play with the town budget spreadsheet. Cheryl will send the spreadsheet to all. FinCom members will go through it, calculate and recalculate and come up with recommendations for discussion purposes.

8. Capital Planning Budget--Ellice noted that the plan only includes needs and not how to pay for it.

9. Next week we will meet with Capital Planning, Select Board and the Highway Department.

We adjourned at 8:30 pm.

Respectfully Submitted by Mary Cleary